

possible at the New York Stock Exchange and was one more example of the openness and generosity of this wonderful city.

Mr. Epstein took me down to the entrance of the trading floor at the Mercantile Exchange. There we met up with Ryman Flippen, the balding director of all Lind-Waldock floor operations, a man with the nervous energy of a roustabout. With Mr. Epstein and Mr. Flippen at my elbows, I was issued a visitor's badge and escorted through the security checkpoint. I could see the need for security. Without it, it would have been easy for any stranger to print up a phony trading badge, amble into the pits, start hollering and waving, and end up owning half the nation's farm output or billions of dollars in Treasury bonds.

To the left of the main door was a bulletin board with a list of names of people who'd been fined by the Mercantile Exchange for wearing cutoff blue jeans, throwing gum on the floor, eating on the floor, and flipping cards improperly. By the nature of these violations, it was obvious that many traders were hardly more than teenagers. The only other places I'd seen such rules were in college dining halls. "You can get fined for many other things," said Mr. Epstein. "Including biting. That actually happens in the crowded pits."

There was a longer list of people whose badges were revoked and who were no longer allowed on the floor. This wasn't for biting. Mr. Epstein said these recent unfortunates had lost all their money, which he called "crapping out." It happened to 40 percent of the futures traders, he said, especially the newest ones. "They come and go pretty fast these days," he continued, sadly shaking his head at the crap-out list. "It used to be more congenial around here, more like a small town. Now it's getting tougher. It's getting so you hardly know your neighbor in the pits."

We entered the trading area, ringed with overhead quote boards. It was at least as big as the floor of the NYSE. Every few seconds, the public-address announcer would page somebody to the telephone. We found ourselves surrounded by messengers in yellow jackets. Most of them had acne.

Ryman Flippen ushered us past the messengers to a bank of telephones at a Lind-Waldock order desk, where the buy and sell